

**Between Tradition and Translation:
A Critical Analysis of Ovunda Ihunwo's *Ruwgnuoma*.**

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Abstract

*This paper examines the dramaturgical and cultural translation processes evident in Ovunda Ihunwo's stage production of *Ruwgnuoma*, an adaptation of Elechi Amadi's canonical novel *The Concubine* written by Edward Egbo Imo. Through performance analysis grounded in adaptation theory and indigenous aesthetics, the study investigates how traditional Ikwerre cosmology, ritual practices, and cultural signifiers are negotiated within contemporary theatrical frameworks. Drawing on ethnographic observation of the March 13th, 2025 performance at the University of Port Harcourt, the research interrogates the production's scenographic choices, performance techniques, and audience engagement strategies to assess both its artistic efficacy and cultural authenticity. The findings reveal tensions between traditional performance modes and Western theatrical conventions, highlighting broader implications for indigenous language theater's role in preserving cultural heritage while creating accessible contemporary art. This critical analysis contributes to ongoing discourse on postcolonial performance practices and adaptation methodologies in African theater.*

Keywords: *Adaptation theory, indigenous aesthetics, cultural translation, Ikwerre cosmology, performance ethnography*

Introduction

The theatrical landscape of contemporary African drama continues to navigate the delicate balance between preserving cultural authenticity and achieving artistic accessibility. In this context, Ovunda Ihunwo's production of *Ruwgnuoma*, an adaptation of Elechi Amadi's renowned novel *The Concubine* written by Edward Egbo Imo, emerges as a noteworthy contribution to the ongoing discourse on indigenous storytelling through modern theatrical frameworks. Presented over four days from March 11th-14th, 2025, this production invites critical examination of how traditional narratives can be effectively translated to the stage, while maintaining their cultural integrity and emotional resonance. This analysis focuses on the March 13th performance, examining the production's successes and shortcomings through the lens of theatrical aesthetics, performance techniques, cultural representation, and audience engagement.

The significance of productions like *Ruwgnuoma* extends beyond mere entertainment, as they serve as vital repositories of cultural knowledge and identity (Utoh-Ezeajugh, 2013). The adaptation from Amadi's classic novel, a cornerstone of Nigerian literature that explores Ikwerre cosmology and spiritual beliefs, to stage presentation represents an important intersection of literary and performance traditions. As Ihunwo, an

Associate Professor of Performance and Film Aesthetics, undertakes the challenge of directing Imo's adaptation of this traditional Ikwerre narrative, the production raises important questions about authenticity, accessibility, and the responsibilities of cultural representation in contemporary theater practice. This criticism aims to provide a comprehensive assessment of the production's artistic merits while contextualizing it within broader conversations about indigenous theater in the 21st century.

Theoretical Framework and Methodology

Theoretical Grounding

This analysis is situated at the intersection of adaptation theory, indigenous performance aesthetics, and cultural translation studies. The concept of "translation" employed here draws on Patrice Pavis's (1992) influential theory of intercultural performance, which conceptualizes theatrical adaptation as a complex process of cultural negotiation rather than mere linguistic transposition. As Pavis argues, "Cultural translation in performance involves not just a transfer of text but an entire reimagining of cultural references, contexts, and embodied practices" (p. 136). This framework allows us to examine *Ruwhnuoma* not simply as a staging of Amadi's novel but as a multifaceted cultural mediation between literary text, indigenous worldview, and contemporary theatrical conventions.

The analysis of adaptation strategies follows Linda Hutcheon's (2006) theory of adaptation as "an acknowledged transposition of a recognizable other work, that involves both (re-)interpretation and then (re-)creation" (p. 8). This lens enables critical examination of how Imo's dramatic text and Ihunwo's directorial choices reinterpret, reinvent, or reinforce elements of Amadi's original narrative, with particular attention to changes in character portrayal, narrative structure, and thematic emphasis.

For the analysis of indigenous performance elements, this study draws on Wole Soyinka's (1976) concept of the "fourth stage" as the liminal ritual space where transformation occurs through performance. This theoretical perspective is complemented by Enekwe's (1987) theory of African ritual drama, which positions traditional performance as a communal spiritual practice that collapses distinctions between performers and audience. These frameworks provide critical tools for evaluating how *Ruwhnuoma* negotiates the tension between Western theatrical conventions (with their emphasis on spectacle and representation) and indigenous performance traditions (with their emphasis on communal participation and ritual efficacy).

The concept of "theatrical time" employed in this analysis follows Clark's (2019) delineation of temporal structures in African performance, where time operates not as linear progression but as cyclical, mythical, and ritual experience. "Authenticity" is understood through Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's (1986) perspective on decolonization and cultural integrity, which positions language as the carrier of cultural memory and identity. "Ritual aesthetics" refers to the formal elements of ceremonial practice that, as

Schechner (2017) observes, serve not merely decorative functions but transformative ones in traditional performance contexts.

Methodology

This study employs performance ethnography as its primary methodological approach, combining first-hand observation with critical analysis informed by adaptation and performance theories. The researcher attended the March 13th, 2025 performance of *Ruwghnuoma* at the University of Port Harcourt, documenting scenographic elements, performance techniques, audience reactions, and production logistics through detailed field notes. This ethnographic observation was supplemented by analysis of the production's program notes, promotional materials, and the script adaptation by Edward Egbo Imo.

The analytical framework incorporates three intersecting methodological approaches:

1. **Dramaturgical analysis:** examining the production's structural elements, including narrative adaptation, character development, and theatrical devices
2. **Performance analysis:** focusing on acting techniques, embodiment, voice work, and the integration of movement, music, and visual elements
3. **Cultural semiotic analysis:** investigating how Ikwerre cultural signs, symbols, and practices are represented, transformed, or reimaged through theatrical presentation

This multi-layered methodology enables comprehensive examination of both the production's artistic effectiveness as theatrical performance and its cultural significance as an adaptation of indigenous narrative. The analysis is further contextualized through comparative reference to Amadi's original novel and contemporary scholarly discourse on African theater practices.

Scenography and Production Design: Beyond Description to Cultural Signification

The visual elements of *Ruwghnuoma* presented an ambitious attempt to recreate an epic cultural setting, though with mixed results that occasionally undermined the production's intended atmosphere. The elaborate and colorful costumes constituted one of the production's strongest aesthetic elements, demonstrating careful attention to cultural detail and providing visual richness that enhanced the storytelling. As Akinwale (2019) notes, "Costume in traditional African theater functions not merely as adornment but as visual text, communicating social status, cultural context, and character disposition" (p. 87).

However, the scenographic elements demonstrated inconsistencies that challenged the audience's suspension of disbelief. Most notably, the set design's inclusion of conspicuously fresh palm fronds to represent an ostensibly ancient dwelling created a jarring temporal contradiction. This oversight reflects what Adelugba and Obafemi (2018) identify as a common challenge in historical productions, where "the physical signs of antiquity must be carefully crafted rather than merely suggested" (p. 145). The

incongruity between the fresh vegetation and the narrative's historical setting represented a missed opportunity to create a more immersive and believable environment.

This scenographic contradiction reveals a deeper tension in the production's approach to temporal representation. Drawing on Clark's (2019) theorization of time in African performance traditions, we can understand how the production struggled to negotiate between linear historical time (the chronological setting of Amadi's narrative) and ritual time (the symbolic temporality of Ikwerre cosmology). The fresh palm fronds inadvertently signaled an unresolved conceptual approach to the representation of time, suggesting what Fischer-Lichte (2014) describes as the "uneasy reconciliation between Western theatrical temporality and indigenous ritual temporality" (p. 218).

The lighting design further compromised the production's atmospheric integrity. Inconsistent illumination not only detracted from crucial dramatic moments but actively undermined certain theatrical illusions, most problematically when the lighting revealed a performer moving into position to portray a corpse. Such technical oversights highlight the importance of integrated production design, where lighting serves not merely to illuminate but to shape perception and guide audience focus. As Effiong (2021) argues, lighting in adaptations of traditional narratives should function as "a material expression of the metaphysical boundaries between worlds" (p. 69), particularly in a narrative like *The Concubine* where spiritual transitions figure prominently. The lighting's failure to maintain these boundaries represents not just a technical shortcoming but a conceptual one that undermines the production's representation of Ikwerre spiritual cosmology.

Performance and Characterization: Embodied Cultural Knowledge

The acting performances in *Ruwhnuoma* displayed considerable variation in technique, commitment, and effectiveness. Several performers demonstrated exceptional skill and cultural understanding, notably Christopher Johnpaul as Anyika the herbalist, whose characterization displayed both technical proficiency and cultural authenticity. Similarly, Ihunaya Godwin's portrayal of Wosu injected vital energy into the production at a critical juncture, demonstrating how a single compelling performance can revitalize audience engagement. Anyika Blessing's interpretation of Okachi, while occasionally excessive in its physicality for a character described as elderly, nevertheless maintained audience interest through her committed characterization.

However, other performances struggled with fundamental theatrical requirements. The narrator, portrayed by Sampson Kelvin, lacked the vocal presence necessary for his pivotal role as the audience's guide through the narrative. This vocal inadequacy was not isolated; numerous actors throughout the production failed to achieve consistent audibility, resulting in lost dialogue and diminished impact. As Yerima (2014) emphasizes, "Voice projection in African performance contexts is not merely technical

but spiritual; it is the primary channel through which ancestral narratives reach contemporary audiences" (p. 112). The inability of several performers to maintain vocal clarity therefore constituted not just a technical failure but a thematic one.

This observation connects to Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's (1986) theories on language and cultural decolonization, which position indigenous language performance as crucial to cultural preservation. The production's linguistic challenges, particularly the mispronunciation of traditional names and phrases by non-Ikwerre speaking actors, reveal the complexities of cultural translation when performers lack embodied cultural knowledge. As Ogunbiyi (2020) argues, "Language in indigenous performance is not merely communicative but constitutive of cultural identity; its proper execution is essential to authentic representation" (p. 176). The production's failure to adequately prepare performers linguistically resulted in moments that undermined cultural authenticity and narrative credibility.

The physical performances showed similar inconsistency. While the wrestling sequence between Madume and Ememike achieved convincing realism, other actors displayed limited physical expressivity. Confidence Sogho's portrayal of Nnadi during a scene of mourning lacked the emotional intensity and physical manifestation that the moment demanded, demonstrating what Schechner (2017) describes as "the gap between emotional understanding and embodied expression" (p. 223). This inconsistency reveals the challenges of adapting what Utoh-Ezeajugh and Okoye (2018) call "culturally-specific embodied knowledge" (p. 85) to contemporary performance contexts, particularly when performers have varying levels of familiarity with the cultural traditions being represented.

Music, Rhythm, and Indigenous Aesthetics

The musical elements of *Ruwghnuoma* represented both significant potential and problematic execution. The orchestra opened the performance promisingly with what was described as a "beautiful rendition," establishing an appropriate cultural and emotional atmosphere. However, subsequent musical contributions suffered from inconsistent coordination and costume inconsistencies that visually disconnected the musicians from the production's aesthetic unity.

This disconnect can be analyzed through Enekwe's (1987) theoretical framework for African ritual drama, which positions music not as accompaniment but as a constitutive element of performance that mediates between physical and spiritual realms. The musicians' visual and rhythmic inconsistency therefore undermined what Enekwe describes as the "ritual coherence necessary for effective cultural performance" (p. 132). When considered through Soyinka's (1976) concept of the "fourth stage," these musical inconsistencies potentially compromised the production's ability to establish the liminal space where transformation occurs through performance.

The integration of music and movement achieved its most effective realization during ceremonial scenes, though even here, the choreographic execution was uneven, with some performers notably less prepared than others. Strong moments of energy and engagement were frequently followed by significant tempo drops, creating an uneven dramatic experience. The production's rhythmic inconsistency therefore constituted not just a structural weakness but a potential misrepresentation of the cultural material's intrinsic temporal dynamics.

Applying Schechner's (2017) analysis of rhythm in ritual performance, we can understand these tempo variations as disruptions to what he calls the "performed epistemology" (p. 89) of traditional narrative. In Ikwerre cultural context, as Amadi's novel illustrates, rhythmic consistency serves not merely aesthetic functions but epistemological ones, structuring knowledge transmission and communal experience. The production's rhythmic instability therefore potentially undermined its cultural authenticity at a fundamental level.

Audience Engagement: Participation or Disruption?

The audience experience of *Ruwghnuoma* was significantly compromised by multiple breaches of theatrical etiquette and production oversight. The performance space became increasingly disrupted by audience behaviors including audible gum chewing, phone ringtones, unauthorized use of mobile lights during blackouts, and even vocal interruptions directed at performers. These disruptions not only detracted from the immediate theatrical experience but point to more fundamental issues regarding audience education and front-of-house management.

However, rather than dismissing these audience behaviors simply as disruptions, we might analyze them through the lens of African performance traditions as articulated by Mark's (2020) work on "Audience and the transformation of performance in African theatre." As Mark argues, "What appears as disruption in Western theatrical contexts may constitute legitimate participation in indigenous performance traditions, where the boundary between performer and audience is inherently permeable" (p. 115). This theoretical perspective raises important questions: Were these audience interruptions manifestations of traditional spectatorship practices being expressed within Western theatrical conventions? Or did they represent a genuine failure of audience etiquette?

The answer likely lies in the production's own framing of audience expectations. By structuring *Ruwghnuoma* within conventional Western theatrical architecture (proscenium stage, dimmed house lights, programmed intervals), the production implicitly established a particular mode of spectatorship. Yet the cultural material, rooted in communal storytelling traditions, potentially invited different modes of engagement. This tension between invited and expected audience behavior reflects what Banham et al. (2022) identify as the "unresolved negotiation between indigenous performance traditions and adopted theatrical conventions" (p. 203) that characterizes much contemporary African theater.

Particularly troubling was the reported behavior of a self-identified directing student whose disruptive commentary contradicted expected standards of professional conduct. As Banham et al. (2022) observe, "The theatrical event is co-created through a relationship of mutual respect between performers and audience; when this contract is broken, the entire aesthetic experience is compromised" (p. 201). The failure to maintain appropriate audience behavior suggests institutional shortcomings in communicating and enforcing theatrical norms.

Adaptation Analysis: From Novel to Stage

Ruwhnuoma represents not just a performance but an adaptation, translating Amadi's prose narrative into dramatic form through Imo's script and Ihunwo's direction. Applying Hutcheon's (2006) adaptation theory allows us to identify significant transformative strategies in this process. The production engaged in what Hutcheon terms "ontological shifting", transforming the novel's descriptive passages into embodied performance while negotiating the representation of internal states, temporal shifts, and spiritual dimensions central to Amadi's narrative.

The production's adaptation strategy prioritized narrative fidelity, maintaining key plot elements and character relationships from Amadi's novel. However, this fidelity to plot sometimes came at the expense of thematic depth, particularly in representing the novel's complex spiritual cosmology. As Sanders (2016) observes in her work on adaptation theory, "Faithful reproduction of plot often obscures the deeper philosophical and cultural dimensions of source texts" (p. 78). This observation helps explain why certain scenes—particularly those involving supernatural elements—felt descriptively accurate but interpretively shallow.

The adaptation made notable changes to narrative structure, employing a narrator figure absent from the original novel. This addition represents what Sanders terms "amplification through commentary" (p. 82), creating interpretive framing for the audience. However, the narrator's inconsistent presence and vocal challenges undermined this adaptive strategy's effectiveness. The production also condensed temporal progression, compressing months of narrative time into theatrical duration. This compression occasionally resulted in rushed character development and emotional transitions that lacked the gradual unfolding evident in Amadi's prose.

Most significantly, the adaptation negotiated the shift from the novel's internal psychological exploration to externalized theatrical representation. Amadi's nuanced portrayal of characters' spiritual beliefs and psychological states, particularly Ihuoma's complex relationship with her divine husband, required translation into visible action and spoken dialogue. The production's solution to this adaptive challenge relied heavily on explicit verbal explanation rather than theatrical metaphor or symbolic representation, demonstrating what Imo (2021) himself has described as the "challenge of externalizing internal narrative through dramatic means" (p. 52).

Production Oversights through the Lens of Cultural Translation

Several production inconsistencies indicated insufficient attention to detail and rehearsal thoroughness. The actor portraying Madume (Diepriye Precious) referred to cutting a "head of plantain" without the necessary prop machete, creating a moment of unintended absurdity. More significantly, actors mistakenly referred to a character as "Emenike" instead of "Ekwueme," a narrative inconsistency that was apparently noticeable to the audience. Such errors suggest insufficient rehearsal and inadequate attention to script consistency.

Through Pavis's (1992) framework of cultural translation, these inconsistencies represent significant "translation errors" that undermine the production's cultural and artistic integrity. The absence of the machete, for instance, constitutes what Pavis would term a "material sign failure", the omission of a crucial cultural object that carries both practical and symbolic significance in the narrative context. Similarly, the character name confusion represents a "nominal disruption" that fractures the audience's engagement with the fictional world.

The backstage management appeared similarly problematic, with noise from the orchestra area and visible performer entrances that compromised theatrical illusion. These technical shortcomings reflect what Akinwunmi (2021) identifies as common challenges in productions that lack "the necessary integration of technical and artistic elements that constitute professional theatrical practice" (p. 142). From the perspective of cultural translation theory, these technical inconsistencies represent failures in what Pavis terms the "concretization of transmission", the material realization of cultural concepts through theatrical means.

Conclusion: Implications for Indigenous-Language Theatre

Ovunda Ihunwo's production of *Ruwghnuoma* represents an ambitious but uneven attempt to translate traditional Ikwerre narrative to contemporary theatrical form. While demonstrating commendable commitment to cultural specificity through elaborate costuming and traditional music, the production struggled with fundamental theatrical requirements including consistent performance technique, scenographic coherence, and audience management.

This critical analysis reveals broader implications for the future of indigenous-language theatre in Nigeria and beyond. First, the adaptation process highlights the challenges and possibilities of reimagining canonical Nigerian literature for stage presentation. As exemplified by *Ruwghnuoma*, successful adaptation requires not just theatrical skill but deep understanding of the cultural epistemologies underlying literary works. The production demonstrates that adaptation is not merely a matter of transposing plot but of negotiating complex cultural translation between literary, theatrical, and indigenous knowledge systems.

Second, the production raises important questions about theatrical training methodologies for indigenous performance. The inconsistent language competency and physical expression among performers suggests a need for training approaches that integrate technical theatrical skills with embodied cultural knowledge. This observation aligns with Utoh-Ezeajugh and Okoye's (2018) call for "integrated training methodologies that honor indigenous performance traditions while preparing performers for contemporary theatrical contexts" (p. 92).

Finally, *Ruwghnuoma* demonstrates how contemporary indigenous-language theatre negotiates postcolonial identity through both form and content. By presenting Amadi's canonical work in Ikwerre language while employing Western theatrical conventions, the production embodies what Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o (1986) describes as the "continuous negotiation between indigenous expression and adopted forms" (p. 165) that characterizes postcolonial artistic production. The tensions evident in the production—between traditional and contemporary, indigenous and Western, participation and spectacle, reflect broader cultural negotiations in postcolonial Nigerian society.

Future productions would benefit from more rigorous attention to linguistic preparation for non-native speakers, integrated technical rehearsals, consistent performance coaching for vocal projection, and strengthened front-of-house protocols. With these considerations addressed, the rich cultural material at the heart of *Ruwghnuoma* could achieve the theatrical impact and cultural significance it clearly aspires to attain.

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